

A HISTORY OF CONFLICT

The 3,380 km-long Sino-Indian boundary remains a sticky issue, although 11 rounds of talks have been held between the two nations. China continues to penetrate the borders even as it engages in a dialogue.

JAN 23, 1959: Chou en Lai spells out, for the first time, China's claim over 40,000 sq miles of Indian territory in Ladakh and NEFA.

AUG 25, 1959: Chinese troops open fire on an Indian picket near Migyitun in Ladakh killing one Indian soldier and overrun the outpost at Longju in Ladakh.

Former Chinese premier Chou en Lai



OCT 20, 1959: Chinese troops fire at an Indian patrol in Aksai Chin, killing nine and capturing 10 soldiers.

JUNE 3, 1960: Chinese troops violate the border in Shipki village in NEFA.



Indian and Chinese troops clash during 1962 war

NOV 21, 1961: Fresh Chinese incursions in Ladakh.

JUNE 10, 1962: An armed clash is averted in Galwan Valley in Ladakh as the Chinese withdraw just when India threatens to use force.

SEPT 20, 1962: Chinese forces cross the Mac Mohan Line in Thagla region 2 miles east of Dhola in NEFA and open fire at an auxiliary post.

SEPT 29, 1962: China launches an intense attack on the north-eastern border.

OCT 20, 1962: A multi-pronged attack is launched all along the border from NEFA to Ladakh.

NOV 15, 1962: A massive Chinese attack on the eastern front and Tawang and Walong overrun in the western sector. Heavy shelling at Rezang La and Chushul airports.



Jawaharlal Nehru at a frontier post

NOV 18, 1962: Chinese troops capture Bomdila in NEFA.

FEB 1986: Troops have a face-off at Sumdorong Chu in Arunachal Pradesh, which almost led to a war.

JUNE 2003: Chinese patrols intrude in Arunachal Pradesh in Asaphila region and detain Indian security personnel while the then Indian prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee was visiting China.

yond the so-called tranquil sectors of the middle and western region in the strategic sectors of Asaphila in Arunachal Pradesh. What has been worrying is the alarming rise in the patrols of PLA that have increased to about 50 personnel, while carrying recce missions. In Asaphila, the two countries nearly came to a war situation when there was a face-off between PLA and the Assam Rifles in November 1988. China lays claim to about 250 sq km in this area and analysts believe that control over it can lead to China gaining observational domination over the Indian territory.

Even in the Namkha Chu and Sumdorong Chu areas in Tawang sector of Arunachal Pradesh, China seems intent on straightening the border

INTRUSIONS IN LADAKH HAVE STEPPED UP AND THE CHINESE ARMY HAS ALSO MOUNTED AIR INTRUSIONS.

from Kharsangla in Arunachal Pradesh till the Indo-Bhutan border. "China has been indulging in creeping acquisition over the years, and the Government has tacitly accepted these incursions. We may have already lost several hundred square kilometre in the past few years," says Kiren Rijiju, MP from Arunachal Pradesh (West).

While not many believe China will risk a full-scale war with India, the pattern and the intent behind these incursions seem to lend credence to the theory that China is working

towards laying claim to some parts of the disputed territory. Sources say they claimed 15x10 km in the meeting of the border joint working group in 1995, that was increased to 45 km and now 378 sq km during the exchange of maps in 2000. "The Chinese have a strategic objective to keep India on the tenterhooks and all these incursions are part of a larger design to keep it under pressure if it changes its policy on Tibet or comes too close to the US," says strategic analyst Brahma Chellaney.